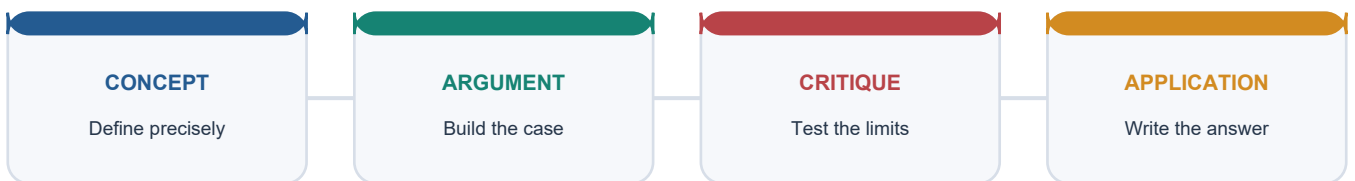


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Later Vedic Phase: Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Later Vedic Phase: Solved Practice Workbook

Exact practice contract: 32 original hard MCQs appear before PYQs; keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 examiner traps are unique. Verified PYQs retain official/provisional-key discipline. Six original Mains models are independently word-counted.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Exact practice contract: These 32 questions appear before every PYQ. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are question-specific.

Q1

1

Which formulation most safely defines the Later Vedic source base?

- A. A layered corpus of later Samhitas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas and early Upanishads
- B. A single chronicle composed at one court in c. 800 BCE and revised annually by royal court scribes
- C. A census that records every region and social group uniformly
- D. A material-culture catalogue independent of ritual authorship

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: it names the main textual families and preserves their layered character. [Q1-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: no single royal chronicle unifies the corpus or its dates. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: elite ritual texts are not population-wide statistical records. [Q1-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the texts must be compared with, not substituted for, archaeology. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: A broad phase cannot be assigned one author, court or composition date.

Q2

2

The main historical significance of the Samaveda is that it

- A. records a regular territorial tax system with fixed rates
- B. reworks many Rigvedic verses for specialised liturgical chant
- C. catalogues PGW settlements and their iron assemblages
- D. systematises the four ashramas in their final classical form

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: fiscal regularity is not the Samaveda's genre or purpose. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: musical-liturgical arrangement illuminates growing ritual specialisation. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: pottery distributions come from archaeology, not the Samaveda. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: later life-stage systematisation cannot be assigned to this liturgy. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: Do not confuse a text's ritual function with later social or archaeological information.

Q3

3

Why is the Yajurveda especially valuable for Later Vedic reconstruction?

- A. It is the earliest securely dated Indian coin catalogue.
- B. It consists only of philosophical dialogues on atman.
- C. It connects sacrificial formulae with prescribed ritual actions.
- D. It provides a neutral account of every household's daily practice.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: struck coinage and numismatic catalogues belong to later evidence. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: early Upanishads, not the whole Yajurveda, centre such dialogues. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: formula plus procedure reveals the organisation of elaborate sacrifice. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: prescribed ritual action cannot be treated as universal ethnography. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: A ritual manual proves normative design more securely than actual frequency.

Q4

4

Which statement about the Atharvaveda is most defensible?

- A. It is only a manual for horse sacrifice and royal conquest. and excludes all domestic or healing concerns
- B. It proves a fully monetised economy through named coins.
- C. It is later than the entire Puranic corpus.
- D. It preserves charms and household concerns involving health, marriage and fertility.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: its subject range extends well beyond royal shrauta rites. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: valuables and value terms do not establish minted currency. [Q4-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: early Vedic textual layers predate the much later Puranic compilations. [Q4-C]
- **D:** Correct: these concerns widen the social world visible beyond grand public ritual. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: Household visibility broadens evidence but still does not create a social census.

Q5

5

Brahmana texts should primarily be read as

- A. priestly expositions of ritual, status, cosmology and kingship
- B. verbatim transcripts of village assemblies across north India issued by territorial royal secretaries
- C. archaeological field reports on PGW stratigraphy
- D. legal codes already identical to mature Dharmashastra

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: their explanatory ritual prose is the source's central genre. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: neither verbatim minutes nor pan-regional coverage is demonstrated. [Q5-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: stratigraphy is an archaeological method external to the corpus. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: later legal systematisation must not be projected backward. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: Genre controls inference: prescriptive ritual prose is not direct administrative reportage.

Q6

6

The conventional c. 1000-600 BCE range is best used as

- A. an exact date stamped on every Brahmana and Upanishadic passage
- B. a broad working horizon containing internal textual and regional sequences
- C. proof that all PGW levels were occupied by one Vedic-speaking people
- D. the completed chronology of second urbanisation

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: composition, transmission and redaction occurred across time. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: the range organises a phase without erasing internal chronology. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: overlap cannot identify language or ethnicity from pottery. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: mature urbanisation intensifies around and after the phase's end. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: Periodisation is a scaffold, not permission to flatten every source into one date.

Q7

7

Which sequence most accurately represents the geographical reorientation?

- A. Videha to Punjab to Kurukshetra as one westward movement
- B. The entire subcontinent becoming Kuru territory simultaneously
- C. North-western baseline to Kuru-Panchala, followed by later eastern extensions
- D. A direct shift from Harappan cities to Magadhan imperial provinces under a continuous imperial administration

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the principal textual reorientation runs broadly eastward. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Kuru power was regional, not pan-subcontinental. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: it preserves core geography and later regional chronology. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: it collapses several different horizons and state forms. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: Keep Kuru-Panchala central and Kosala-Videha chronologically later.

Q8

8

What can PGW establish most securely?

- A. The Vedic language spoken at every excavated settlement and the ritual affiliation of all residents
- B. A single ethnic identity extending across all sites
- C. The exact historicity of every epic episode
- D. A material chronology of pottery, habitation and associated finds

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: ceramics cannot independently recover spoken language. [Q8-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: an assemblage distribution is not an ethnic census. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: archaeological correlation cannot verify a literary narrative wholesale. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: these are direct strengths of archaeological evidence. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: Pottery labels material practice; people, language and texts require separate evidence.

Q9

9

In Later Vedic contexts, shyama-ayas or krishna-ayas most safely indicate

- A. dark or black metal commonly associated with iron
- B. a standard silver coin issued by Kuru kings
- C. a uniform iron ploughshare found at every PGW site
- D. a textual name for Northern Black Polished Ware

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: the colour term distinguishes the later iron association from earlier generic ayas. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: neither expression denotes a securely minted Kuru coin. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: textual terminology cannot guarantee one tool at all sites. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: NBPW is a later archaeological ceramic horizon. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: Earlier ayas need not mean iron, and later black metal does not specify every object.

Q10

10

Why is an iron-determinist explanation inadequate?

- A. Iron was unknown anywhere in the subcontinent before c. 600 BCE.
- B. Its effects depended on labour, fuel, traction, crops, settlement and institutions.
- C. Iron objects occur only in ritual texts and never in archaeology.
- D. Every early iron artefact was an agricultural ploughshare.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: regional iron evidence precedes that date. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: technology creates capacities whose consequences require social mediation. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: archaeological iron is central to the discussion. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: weapons, tools and prestige uses varied by context. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: One technology cannot serve as a self-acting cause of agrarian or political transformation.

Q11

11

The best description of Later Vedic agriculture is

- A. the first appearance of cultivation anywhere in Vedic society through a sudden prohibition on cattle keeping
- B. a complete replacement of cattle by rice cultivation
- C. greater stability and scale of plough agriculture with crop and cattle continuity
- D. a plantation system based on coined wages

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: cultivation is attested in the earlier horizon. [Q11-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: cattle retained traction, ritual and wealth functions. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: it captures intensification without inventing a total break. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: wage plantations and coin dependence are anachronistic. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Use intensification and reweighting, not an origin story for agriculture.

Q12

12

Why did surplus become politically important?

- A. It ended all subsistence risks and ecological variation.
- B. It proved private landownership was universal.
- C. It immediately produced large cities throughout the Ganga basin. with monetised markets and permanent fortifications
- D. Stored or appropriable production could sustain rulers, priests and specialists.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: harvest variability and household reproduction continued. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: land-control evidence remains partial and debated. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: most settlements remained rural and urbanisation was incomplete. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: this mechanism links agrarian stability to institutional differentiation. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Surplus is a social relation of storage and appropriation, not merely a bigger harvest.

Q13

13

Long lists of Later Vedic occupations most directly support

- A. increasing craft and service specialisation
- B. fully hereditary urban guilds in every settlement
- C. a universal salaried labour market
- D. the disappearance of household production

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: differentiated occupations are visible without requiring later institutions. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: texts do not establish universal guild organisation or heredity. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: hired wage labour is not demonstrated as the dominant system. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: households continued to organise much production. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Occupational differentiation must not be inflated into a mature urban labour regime.

Q14

14

Which statement about nishka, satamana and krishnala is safest?

- A. They were all standard struck coins with royal portraits.
- B. They could denote valuables, weights or value units without proving coinage.
- C. They show that barter and gift exchange had disappeared.
- D. They belonged exclusively to Mauryan fiscal terminology.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: no such uniform portrait coinage is established for the phase. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: context-sensitive value is distinct from minted currency. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: goods, cattle, gifts and produce remained important. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the terms have earlier ritual-economic contexts. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: A unit of value or metal object is not automatically a coin.

Q15

15

The jana-to-janapada transition refers primarily to

- A. the replacement of every lineage by a salaried bureaucracy
- B. the conversion of PGW pottery into a political constitution through a standard constitution written on pottery
- C. growing attachment of a people and ruler to a territorial domain
- D. the disappearance of pastoral mobility from all regions

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: kin and personal ties remained politically important. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: pottery cannot create or define a constitution. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: territoriality supplemented older people-centred identity. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: mobility and cattle keeping continued unevenly. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Territorialisation is gradual and does not abolish kinship by definition.

Q16

16

Kuru formation is most defensibly associated with

- A. a Mauryan province governed from Pataliputra
- B. the first fully urban republic of the middle Ganga valley with elected magistrates and minted civic coinage
- C. a single archaeologically proven epic war
- D. the coalescence of Bharata-Puru traditions in an upper-doab territorial centre

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Mauryan empire is many centuries later. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Kuru kingship and the Mahajanapada urban horizon are distinct. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: archaeology does not verify the epic narrative wholesale. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: it combines kin traditions, territory and ritual consolidation. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Kuru political history should not be reduced to literal epic reconstruction.

Q17

17

Ratnins are best understood as

- A. ritual-political associates and functionaries whose lists reveal transitional kingship

- B. a fixed cabinet with identical ministries in every kingdom whose departments and salaries were fixed across kingdoms
- C. elected delegates of a universal peasant assembly
- D. coin-minting guild heads recognised by PGW pottery

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: the jewel-offering network mixes kin, household and specialised roles. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: lists vary and cannot be standardised into modern departments. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: neither universal election nor peasant representation is supported. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: their identity is textual-ritual, not ceramic or numismatic. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Administrative-sounding translations must retain variable function and ritual context.

Q18

18

Which fiscal formulation is most accurate?

- A. Bali was always a voluntary gift with no coercive tendency.
- B. Bali and bhaga became more regular, but no mature assessed bureaucracy is proved.
- C. Shulka was a universal one-sixth land tax administered by provinces.
- D. Dakshina replaced all political revenue and war booty.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: texts indicate movement toward obligation and control. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: extraction strengthened while institutional limits remained. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: neither one universal rate nor provincial machinery is secure. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: ritual fees coexisted with tribute, shares and booty. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Do not borrow later tax rates or administrative machinery to fill evidentiary gaps.

Q19

19

What happened to sabha and samiti in the Later Vedic phase?

- A. They became identical to modern elected legislatures. with universal adult franchise and written statutes
- B. They disappeared everywhere as soon as iron appeared.
- C. They continued with changing or narrowing influence as royal power grew.
- D. They were names for sacrificial coins paid to priests.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: collective bodies cannot be translated into modern parliament. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: technological and institutional change had no single switch date. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: continued references coexist with reduced relative weight. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: assembly terms are not coin or fee denominations. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: State decline or change in textual prominence, not total disappearance.

Q20

20

References to ten-generation kingdoms most directly suggest

- A. that all succession disputes had ended
- B. that kingship remained purely temporary and non-hereditary renewed separately at every seasonal assembly
- C. that every ruler controlled an empire
- D. a strengthening hereditary tendency still open to ratification or exceptional expulsion

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: texts preserve usurpation and expulsion possibilities. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: multi-generation rule points in the opposite direction. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: hereditary continuity does not prove imperial scale. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: it combines consolidation with surviving political contingency. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: Hereditary tendency is not absolute primogeniture or unlimited sovereignty.

Q21

21

The chief political function of royal sacrifices was to

- A. stage legitimacy, hierarchy, alliance and sovereignty through costly ritual
- B. measure exact administrative borders with cadastral precision through an official horse-route cadastral survey
- C. replace all warfare and tribute with prayer
- D. abolish dependence on priests and ratnins

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: performance turned resources and sacred expertise into public authority. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: prescriptive routes or rites are not territorial surveys. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: warfare, extraction and ritual remained interconnected. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the ceremonies displayed dependence on specialist networks. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: A sovereignty claim can exceed the territory effectively administered.

Q22

22

Which varna statement is most accurate?

- A. Later Vedic society already possessed every later jati and untouchability rule. and already fixed by uniform local endogamy
- B. Fourfold hierarchy sharpened as ideology, but lived groups and occupations remained more varied.
- C. Varna disappeared because territorial kingship replaced social status.
- D. The Purusha Sukta is an archaeological inscription from a PGW site.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: later caste structures cannot be projected wholesale backward. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: ideological consolidation coexisted with social fluidity and diversity. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: territorial power and hierarchy reinforced rather than erased one another. [Q22-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: it is a textual hymn, not an excavated inscription. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Varna is a macro-schema; jati histories require later and local evidence.

Q23

23

The Brahmana-Kshatriya relationship is best described as

- A. complete separation between ritual and political power without any overlap of patronage or ritual
- B. permanent warfare that prevented royal sacrifice
- C. mutual dependence in rule and ritual combined with status competition
- D. equality with Vaishyas and Shudras in privilege and extraction

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: purohita and royal sacrifice demonstrate close interaction. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: competition did not eliminate cooperation. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: brahma and kshatra could be complementary and contested. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the textual hierarchy explicitly differentiates rights and roles. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: Do not reduce a complex elite partnership to either harmony or conflict alone.

Q24

24

Which pairing is historically safest?

- A. Vaishya-ritual exemption; Shudra-exclusive Vedic learning under a universal tax-free priestly settlement
- B. Vaishya-imperial governor; Shudra-PGW priest
- C. Vaishya-non-producer; Shudra-tax-free noble
- D. Vaishya-producer and tribute payer; Shudra-subordinated with restricted ritual access

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses the dominant textual allocation of privilege. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: neither pairing is supported by source categories. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Vaishya production and elite exemption claims contradict it. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: it captures the normative hierarchy while leaving practice qualified. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Normative subordination is real evidence, but it is not a complete occupational census.

Q25

25

Gotra in the Later Vedic context most safely indicates

- A. a developing patrilineal descent marker connected with exogamy
- B. a provincial tax district surveyed by the Kuru state
- C. a guild monopoly over cattle markets
- D. a fully unchanged marriage code applied to every community

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: descent and same-gotra marriage restrictions become more visible. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: territorial fiscal administration is not the term's function. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: cattle-pen etymology does not create a market guild. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the system developed and varied rather than appearing complete. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: Do not project later detailed gotra lists and rules into every early context.

Q26

26

Which conclusion about women is most defensible?

- A. Gargi and Maitreyi prove universal female education.
- B. Patriarchal norms strengthened, while work, ritual roles and elite debate show uneven agency.
- C. All women were excluded from every ritual and economic activity, including household production and philosophical instruction
- D. The Maitrayani assembly statement is a census of all Indian regions.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: named elite examples cannot establish population-wide access. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: it states the trend and its domain-specific qualifications. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: wives, queens and productive work contradict total exclusion. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: one prescriptive passage has limited representativeness. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Exceptional visibility qualifies a trend without cancelling structural patriarchy.

Q27

27

The ashrama system should be described as

- A. fully fixed into four compulsory stages for everyone by c. 1000 BCE with no household stage or teacher-pupil discipline
- B. absent until the Gupta period
- C. developing from student and householder anchors toward later forest and renunciant systematisation
- D. an archaeological sequence defined by four pottery styles

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the classical sequence developed over time and access was unequal. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Vedic and Upanishadic milieus contain earlier life-stage ideas. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: it preserves chronology and avoids a completed-system projection. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: ashrama is a normative life-stage idea, not ceramic chronology. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Developmental language is mandatory where later textual codification is clearer.

Q28

28

Which priest-function match is correct?

- A. Hotri-physical Yajurvedic procedure; adhvaryu-Samavedic singing and an entirely separate priestly bureaucracy
- B. Udgatri-Rigvedic recitation; brahman-chariot command

- C. Adhvaryu-philosophical debate only; hotri-tax collection
- D. Hotri-Rigvedic recitation; udgatri-Samavedic chant; adhvaryu-ritual procedure

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it exchanges the distinctive ritual specialisations. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the udgatri sings and the supervising brahman is not a commander. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: neither role is defined by those exclusive functions. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: the triad captures the principal textual-performance division. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Priestly labels refer to ritual work; avoid modern administrative translations.

Q29

29

Which religious change is best framed?

- A. Prajapati, Vishnu and Rudra gained prominence while older deities continued.
- B. Indra and Agni vanished from all later texts. while older gods were prohibited from ritual recitation
- C. Classical Puranic sects appeared fully formed by c. 1000 BCE.
- D. Ritual ceased as soon as Upanishadic speculation began.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: reweighting with continuity is the source-safe conclusion. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: older deities retained important ritual roles. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: later sectarian systematisation cannot be projected backward. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: speculation emerged within an active ritual world. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Religious history is cumulative; prominence does not equal total replacement.

Q30

30

The early Upanishadic turn is most accurately described as

- A. a complete rejection of every Vedic text and ritual
- B. an internal critique and reinterpretation centred on knowledge, self and ultimate reality
- C. one uniform doctrine written at a single date whose wording, chronology and conclusions never differ
- D. the beginning of Puranic temple worship

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Upanishads remain within shruti and reuse ritual vocabulary. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: interiorisation and inquiry coexist with continuity. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: texts and passages differ in chronology and position. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the genre and institutional horizon are different. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Do not project later Vedanta uniformity onto diverse early dialogues.

Q31

31

The Rig-to-Later Vedic comparison is best expressed as

- A. a change from no hierarchy to the first social inequality
- B. an overnight replacement of all kin and pastoral forms
- C. a gradual regional reweighting toward agrarian, territorial and stratified institutions
- D. a direct transition from village chiefship to Mauryan empire under one universal dynastic conquest and legal code

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: differentiation already existed in the earlier horizon. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: cattle, kin and assemblies continued in changed forms. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: it combines direction, scale and continuity. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: several centuries and intermediate formations are omitted. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Binary contrasts earn easy elimination but poor historical analysis.

Q32

32

How should Later Vedic society be related to the Mahajanapada and second-urbanisation horizon?

- A. As exactly the same political and material formation with no later regional or institutional transformations
- B. As proof that coinage and NBPW were universal before c. 1000 BCE
- C. As unrelated, with no agrarian or territorial continuity
- D. As a precursor supplying some conditions but not the complete later outcome

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the later horizon adds larger states, towns, coinage and distinct regional dynamics. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: both chronology and universality are false. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: surplus and territorialisation provide meaningful connections. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: a precursor formulation avoids both identity and disconnection. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: Teleology is avoided by naming enabling conditions and additional later causes.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AND KEY DISCIPLINE

The 2024 Prelims Set-A wording and official Series-A key are locally verified. The 2026 Set-A wording is locally verified, but the locally held Series-A key is **provisional, not an official final UPSC key**. UPSC publishes no official descriptive model answers for the Mains questions below.

VERIFIED PRELIMS PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q58: UPANISHADS AND PURANAS

Question as printed: Consider the following statements:

1. There are no parables in Upanishads.
2. Upanishads were composed earlier than the Puranas.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

Option	Combination	Status
A	1 only	Incorrect

Option	Combination	Status
B	2 only	Correct - official Series-A key
C	Both 1 and 2	Incorrect
D	Neither 1 nor 2	Incorrect

Answer: B. Statement 1 fails because early Upanishadic teaching uses dialogue, narrative, analogy and parable-like instruction; the Chandogya's Uddalaka-Shvetaketu teaching is a named example. Statement 2 is correct as a relative chronology: early Upanishads belong to the later Vedic/early first-millennium BCE milieu, whereas the Puranas were compiled and expanded much later. Individual texts remain layered.

PYQ trap: One counterexample defeats the universal word "no"; relative chronology does not require one composition date for each corpus.

ADJACENT PRELIMS PYQ - 2026 GS-I Q20: KSHETRA-PATNI

Question as printed: In which one among the following texts does the term *kshetra-patni* ('mistress of the field') originate?

Option	Text	Status
A	Rigveda	Distinguish masculine <i>kshetra-pati</i> in Rigveda 4.57
B	Atharvaveda	LOCAL PROVISIONAL SERIES-A KEY
C	Ashtadhyayi	Later grammatical text
D	Arthashastra	Later statecraft text

Answer status: B under the locally held provisional key; **not officially final**. The item is adjacent because the Atharvaveda belongs to the Later Vedic source corpus. Exact lexical attribution must not be inferred from the similar masculine expression *kshetra-pati*, and no hymn citation is invented here.

PYQ trap: Preserve the printed question, provisional key status and lexical distinction as three separate claims.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q1

Verified wording: Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (Answer in 150 words.)

Demand decoding: "Underline" requires compact paired changes. Society and economy must organise the answer; geography, polity and religion should appear only where they explain those changes.

Instructional model answer (125 words):

Rigvedic society was organised chiefly through *jana*, *vis* and mobile or semi-settled *grama*, with cattle-centred prestige alongside cultivation and household crafts. In the Later Vedic phase, the core shifted to Kuru-Panchala and the upper Ganga, where more persistent settlements, plough agriculture, rice and wider crop production supported larger surplus. Crafts differentiated, while *bali* and *bhaga* made production more regularly appropriable, though coinage and a mature tax bureaucracy were absent. Social identity became more territorial through *janapada* tendencies. Brahmana-Kshatriya privilege sharpened; Vaishyas were represented as producers and tribute payers, and Shudras as subordinate. Gotra, patrilineal inheritance and household authority strengthened, with uneven female agency. Thus the change was gradual agrarianisation, territorialisation and stratification, not the disappearance of cattle, kinship or assemblies.

Why this earns marks: It uses explicit change verbs, named institutions, one continuity line and a fiscal/coinage limit within 150 words.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q11

Verified wording: What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (Answer in 250 words.)

Demand decoding: Answer both society and religion across Early and Later Vedic horizons, then test persistence as transformed continuity rather than unchanged survival.

Instructional model answer (220 words):

Vedic society was kin-centred, agro-pastoral, patriarchal and increasingly stratified, but it changed substantially between the Rigvedic and Later Vedic horizons. The earlier vocabulary of *jana*, *vis*, *grama* and *rajan* reflects people-centred chiefship, cattle-valued wealth, cultivation, household crafts and redistributive gifts. Later Kuru-Panchala settlement, plough agriculture and surplus strengthened territorial kingship, *janapada* tendencies and more obligatory *bali*. Fourfold *varna* ideology became sharper: Brahmana ritual authority and Kshatriya power cooperated and competed, while Vaishyas were associated with production and tribute and Shudras with subordination. Patriliney and household authority deepened, although wives, queens, women workers, Gargi and Maitreyi prevent a total-exclusion formula.

Religion centred initially on deities such as Indra, Agni and Varuna, cosmic order (*rita*) and sacrificial reciprocity. Later yajna became elaborate through specialised priests and royal rites such as *rajasuya*, *ashvamedha* and *vajapeya*. Prajapati, Vishnu and Rudra gained prominence. Early Upanishads then reinterpreted ritual through inquiry into *brahman*, *atman*, karma and rebirth.

Some repertoires persist in Vedic recitation, fire ritual, kinship idioms and social hierarchy. Yet regional histories, bhakti, reform, law and constitutional equality have transformed them. Continuity is therefore selective transmission and reinterpretation, not an unchanged Vedic social fossil.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes both phases, answers society, religion and persistence, and qualifies continuity through historical transformation.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Assess the usefulness and limitations of Later Vedic texts for reconstructing society. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (115 words):

Later Vedic texts are indispensable because the Yajurveda links formula to ritual action, the Atharvaveda preserves household concerns, the Brahmanas explain kingship and sacrifice, and early Upanishads record philosophical debate. Together they reveal the vocabulary of *rajan*, *ratnins*, *bali*, *varna*, *gotra*, household authority and priestly specialisation. Their limits are equally important. The corpus is layered, orally transmitted, regionally concentrated and largely produced by male ritual specialists. Prescriptions about Vaishyas, Shudras or women reveal elite ideology more securely than uniform practice. PGW settlements, crops and iron can test material plausibility but cannot identify Vedic language or ethnicity. Used by genre, layer and region, the texts reconstruct institutional trends; treated literally, they become a false social census.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Why should iron be treated as an enabling rather than determining factor in Later Vedic change? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (109 words):

Later textual references to shyama-ayas or krishna-ayas and regional iron tools indicate wider capacities for cutting, woodworking, warfare and cultivation. Finds from PGW and non-PGW contexts can support clearance, carpentry and agrarian intensification. Iron nevertheless did not act alone. Smelting required ore, fuel and skill; cultivation also required labour, ox traction, crops, water, storage and suitable soils. Political effects depended on chiefs' ability to appropriate surplus through bali and bhaga and to organise retainers and ritual networks. Many early objects were weapons or varied tools, while access differed between sites. Therefore iron enlarged the range of possible action, but ecology and institutions converted technical capacity into uneven historical change.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Analyse Kuru state formation and the changing character of Later Vedic kingship. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (175 words):

Kuru state formation joined older kin identities to a more durable territorial and ritual centre. Bharata and Puru traditions are associated with Kuru consolidation in the upper Ganga-Yamuna doab, while Panchala became another major cultural-political focus. Repeated settlement and agrarian surplus made territory and producers more important, encouraging a movement from jana-centred identity toward janapada tendencies. Kingship became more hereditary: the Shatapatha and Aitareya Brahmanas refer to multi-generation kingdoms, although selection motifs and the expulsion of a king preserve collective ratification and exceptional resistance. The ratnahavimshi ceremony incorporated purohita, senani, gramani, queen, suta, bhagadugha and sangrahitri, showing widening capacity as well as royal dependence on kin, household and functionaries. Bali and bhaga became more regular sources of extraction, while rajasuya, ashvamedha and vajapeya converted surplus and priestly expertise into public sovereignty claims. Yet sabha and samiti continued, ratnin lists varied, and no assessed territorial bureaucracy or standing army is securely demonstrated. Kuru polity was therefore a transitional state: more territorial, hereditary and extractive than Rigvedic chiefship, but still embedded in lineage, assembly and ritual networks.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Critically examine varna, household and gender relations in the Later Vedic phase. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (171 words):

Later Vedic texts articulate a sharper hierarchy linking social rank to ritual and productive roles. Brahmanas claimed sacred authority and Kshatriyas coercive power; their partnership supported kingship, although disputes over precedence reveal competition. Vaishyas were represented as agriculturists, cattle keepers and tribute payers, while Shudras faced service obligations and restricted Vedic access. This fourfold varna ideology legitimised inequality but did not yet map every later jati or eliminate occupational fluidity. The household concentrated production, ritual and reproduction under the grihapati. Son preference, male ancestor rites, inheritance and developing gotra exogamy strengthened patriliney. Patriarchal prescriptions also narrowed women's public and ritual access. The Maitrayani statement on male assembly attendance and Atharvan male-child charms are strong normative evidence. Yet wives remained necessary to many sacrifices, queens entered royal ritual, women performed productive work, and Gargi and Maitreyi represent elite intellectual agency. These examples qualify but do not cancel structural subordination. Since the sources are male, elite and prescriptive, the safest verdict is intensified patriarchal and varna ideology with regionally and socially uneven practice.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Examine the relationship among agrarian surplus, extraction and ritual sovereignty in the Later Vedic phase. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (181 words):

A more stable agrarian base in Kuru-Panchala linked settlement, production and political authority. Plough cultivation, rice, barley, wheat, pulses, ox traction and storage made harvests more regularly available beyond immediate household consumption. This did not end pastoralism: cattle remained crucial for traction, food, prestige and sacrifice. Persistent villages and specialised crafts nevertheless increased the resources that could sustain priests, retainers and rulers. Extraction translated production into power. Bali moved toward obligatory tribute, bhaga denoted a ruler's share, and dana and dakshina channelled wealth through patron-priest relations. Such mechanisms were forming revenue institutions, not a Mauryan assessed bureaucracy. Ritual then converted appropriation into legitimacy. The rajasuya consecrated and renewed kingship; the ashvamedha advertised paramountcy; the vajapeya displayed strength and abundance. Ratnins tied these ceremonies to the royal household, military leadership, local mobilisation and collection. Grand sacrifice redistributed animals, grain and valuables while presenting hierarchy as cosmic order. However, ritual prescriptions may exaggerate actual scale, and a horse's route cannot map effective administration. Agrarian surplus, extraction and yajna therefore formed a reinforcing political economy, but their reach remained regional, negotiated and institutionally incomplete.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Discuss the Upanishadic turn as both a critique and a transformation of Later Vedic ritualism. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (204 words):

The early Upanishads emerged from, rather than outside, the Later Vedic ritual world. Brahmana sacrifice had become elaborate through specialised priests, precise formulae, multiple fires and substantial dakshina. Its promise of efficacy and its concentration of authority invited a deeper question: what makes action, speech and knowledge effective? The Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya Upanishads redirect this inquiry through dialogue, story and analogy. Brahman is explored as ultimate reality or sacred potency and atman as the self; karma increasingly links action with consequence and rebirth, while knowledge offers a developing path beyond repeated existence. This is critique because external performance and priestly monopoly are questioned. It is transformation because ritual vocabulary survives in symbolic and interiorised form: the ashvamedha horse can be redescribed as the cosmos, and sacrifice becomes a field of correspondences and knowledge. Gargi, Maitreyi, Janaka and Pravahana also show that debate was not represented as exclusively priestly. Yet texts and passages differ in date and doctrine, remain part of shruti, and do not uniformly reject yajna. Later Vedanta and a fully systematised moksha doctrine must not be projected backward. The Upanishadic turn was therefore plural internal reform: it challenged ritual sufficiency while converting ritual inquiry into reflection on self, reality, action and liberation.

Demand decoding: Follow the directive, confine the chronology, organise the answer through named evidence and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The answer names a text, term, site or institution, explains the historical mechanism and states the source or scale limit.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the specific demand, uses examinable evidence and replaces a descriptive list with a qualified argument.

How to improve under exam conditions: Underline the thesis, one named evidence item in each paragraph and the final qualification.